Matthew 23:26 — Summary

Date: 2026-06-29

Baseline Translation: ESV (English Standard Version)

Original Language: Greek (NA28/Nestle 1904)

Analyst: Peaches (4K Bible Translation Harness)

Passage Context: Seven Woes pericope, the reversal (v26) — Jesus directly answers v25's indictment with a command: cleanse the INSIDE first, that the outside may become clean also. The spatial metaphor inverts: the problem was outside-only cleansing; the remedy is inside-first cleansing. The cup and platter remain the same; the approach reverses.

Diff Analysis: What Got Lost?

What the Standard Translation Loses

#	Standard (ESV)	What's Lost	Why It Matters
1	"blind"	The Greek (τυφλός) means "opaque, as if smoky" — from the root for smoke. Same word as v24. The LSJ shows extensive metaphorical use for blindness of the mind and all senses.	Jesus carries the "blind" epithet from v24. But now it's singular "thou" — one blind Pharisee, not the group. The blindness is now personal.
2	"cleanse"	The Greek (καθαρισε) is categorized as `ritual>purity_rite` — a purification verb used for	ESV's "cleanse" sounds like simple washing.

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		cleansing from leprosy, cleansing the conscience. Same word as v25.	The Greek carries the force of a PURIFICATION RITE. Jesus commands the Pharisee to perform the RITE of purification — starting from the inside.
3	"first"	The Greek (πρῶton) means "firstly in time, place, order, OR importance." The Strong's definition explicitly includes importance.	Not just "first in sequence" but "first in IMPORTANCE." The inside is the FOUNDATION. Without a clean inside, a clean outside is meaningless. The priority IS the theology.
4	"the inside"	The Greek (>ntos) is the same spatial term used in v25's "within." The spatial opposition from v25 is maintained but REVERSED.	V25: you cleanse the OUTSIDE but WITHIN they are full from sin. V26: cleanse the INSIDE first. Jesus reverses the order. The reversal IS the remedy.

#	Standard (ESV)	What's Lost	Why It Matters
5	"cup"	The Greek (potȟrion) means a drinking-vessel — but figuratively "a lot or fate." Same word as v25.	The cup is still a metaphor for one's LOT or FATE. Jesus commands: cleanse the inside of your LOT first. Your portion in life must be cleansed from within.
6	"platter"	The Greek (paρoψis) — same word as v25. The LSJ cites Ev.Matt.23.25 and notes "fresh tastes of misery."	The same bitter-dispensing vessel from v25. Jesus says: cleanse the INSIDE of the very thing that dispenses misery.
7	"that" (purpose clause)	The Greek (ἵna) means "in order that" — denoting the PURPOSE or the RESULT. The inside cleansing is the MEANS; the outside cleanness is the END.	Jesus says "IN ORDER THAT the outside may become clean" (purposive, causal). The outside doesn't just happen to become clean — it becomes clean BECAUSE the inside was cleansed first. The grammar

#	Standard (ESV)	What's Lost	Why It Matters
			encodes causal dependence.
8	"may become"	The Greek (gɪnomai) is middle voice — "to cause to be, to come into being." Dynamic becoming, not static being.	The outside BECOMES clean through the inside cleansing. The becoming is CONDITIONAL — it requires the inside work. The middle voice suggests the inside cleansing GENERATES the outside cleanness.
9	"clean" (adjective)	The Greek (kaθapos) has categories `morality_spirituality>righteousness_holiness` and `ritual>purity_rite`. Not just physically clean but morally PURE, RIGHTEOUS, HOLY.	The outside doesn't just become spotless — it becomes RIGHTEOUS. The cleanness is moral, spiritual, theological. The cup's outside becoming "clean" means becoming HOLY.
10	"also"	The Greek (kaí) means "and, also, too." The outside may become clean ALSO — as well as the inside. Both clean, inside first.	The "also" encodes the goal: BOTH inside and outside clean. But the order matters: inside first,

#	Standard (ESV)	What's Lost	Why It Matters
			outside ALSO. The cleanness spreads from inside to outside — as a consequence, not a performance.

Concepts Flattened

- **The reversal reduced to word order**: V25 says "cleanse the outside... but within they are full from sin." V26 says "cleanse first the inside... that the outside may become clean also." The REVERSAL IS the theology. Jesus corrects the Pharisees' entire approach.
- **Purpose clause reduced to "that"**: The Greek ἵna means "in order that" — purposive, denoting PURPOSE or RESULT. The inside cleansing is the MEANS; the outside cleanness is the END. The outside becomes clean BECAUSE the inside was cleansed.
- **"May become" reduced to static "may become"**: The Greek gιnomai (middle voice, "to cause to be, to come into being") is dynamic — the outside BECOMES clean through the inside cleansing. The becoming is generated, not automatic.
- **"Clean" as moral purity reduced to physical cleanness**: The Greek kaθaρos has categories `morality_spirituality>righteousness_holiness` and `ritual>purity_rite`. The outside becoming "clean" means becoming RIGHTEOUS, HOLY, PURE.
- **Singular "thou" vs. plural "you"**: V25 addresses "you" (plural). V26 addresses "thou" (singular). Jesus narrows from group to individual. The command is personal.

Expanded Translation (4K)

The recovered "director's cut" — original language nuances restored in readable English. Parenthetical notes explain the nuance recovered.

26 Thou blind (and "blind" means opaque, as if smoky — clouded vision of the mind and judgment, not just the eyes) Pharisee (and "Pharisee" means a separatist — one who has made himself exclusively religious, a sect apart), cleanse (and "cleanse" is a purification verb — the same word used for cleansing from leprosy, cleansing the conscience, purifying from stains; its semantic category is "purity rite," not just "wash") first (and "first" means firstly in time, place, order, OR importance — the inside must be cleansed first because it is the foundation) the inside (and "the inside" means that which is within — the interior, the same word used in v25 for where the cup was full from sin) of the cup (and "cup" means a drinking-vessel, but by extension a cupful or draught, and figuratively a LOT or FATE — the cup is a metaphor for one's portion in life) and of the platter (and "platter" means a side-dish — the same receptacle from v25, which the classical lexicon shows used metaphorically for "fresh tastes of misery"), that (and "that" is ἵνα — "in order that," denoting the PURPOSE or the RESULT; the inside cleansing is the MEANS, the outside cleanness is the END) the outside (and "the outside" means the exterior — the same surface the Pharisees were already cleansing in v25) thereof (and "thereof" is the reflexive — of the cup and platter themselves; the outside belongs to the same vessels whose inside must be cleansed) may become (and "may become" is the middle voice — "to cause to be, to come into being"; the outside doesn't just "be" clean — it BECOMES clean through the inside cleansing; the becoming is conditional, not automatic) clean (and "clean" is the adjective form of the same purification root — and its semantic categories include "righteousness/holiness" and "purity rite"; the outside doesn't just become spotless, it becomes RIGHTEOUS, HOLY, PURE) also (and "also" means "and too" — the outside may become clean AS WELL AS the inside; both clean, inside first)!

Baseline Translation (ESV)

> *26 Thou blind Pharisee, cleanse first the inside of the cup and of the platter, that the outside thereof may become clean also.*

Individual Verse Analyses

Each verse has its own detailed analysis file with full Greek text, word-by-word analysis, grammatical observations, cultural context, and cross-references:

- Matthew 23:26 — The reversal: Jesus commands one blind Pharisee (singular "thou") to cleanse (perform a purification rite) FIRST (in importance, not just sequence) the INSIDE (reversing v25's outside-first approach) of the cup (one's lot or fate) and platter (the bitterness-dispensing vessel), THAT (in order that — purposive, causal) the outside thereof (the same surface from v25) MAY BECOME (middle voice — generated, not static) clean (righteous, holy, pure — not just spotless) ALSO (as well as the inside — both clean, inside first)

Theological Insights Recovered

1. **The reversal IS the theology**: V25 condemns: you cleanse the OUTSIDE while the INSIDE is full from robbery and incontinence. V26 commands: cleanse the INSIDE FIRST. Jesus doesn't just add a new indictment — he REVERSES the Pharisees' entire approach. The order reversal (outside-first → inside-first) IS the theological correction. You cannot have purity without substance. The surface without the interior is not purity but performance. Jesus says: start from the inside. The outside will follow.

2. **"First" as importance, not just sequence**: The Greek πρῶton means "firstly in time, place, order, OR importance." Jesus isn't just saying "do this first and then do the outside." He's saying the inside is the FIRST THING — the most important thing. The inside is the FOUNDATION. Without a clean inside, a clean outside is meaningless. The priority IS the theology: substance before surface, reality before appearance, interior before exterior.

3. **The purpose clause: inside cleansing GENERATES outside cleanness**: The Greek ἵna ("in order that") introduces a purpose clause. The inside cleansing is the MEANS; the outside cleanness is the END. Jesus says "cleanse the inside IN ORDER THAT the outside may become clean" — one task, one consequence. The grammar encodes causal dependence: you don't get a clean outside by cleansing the outside. You get a clean outside by cleansing the inside FIRST. The outside cleanness is a CONSEQUENCE of the inside cleanness, not a separate task.

4. **"May become" as conditional generation**: The Greek gιnomai (middle voice, "to cause to be, to come into being") is dynamic — a becoming, not a being. The outside doesn't automatically become clean; it MAY become clean — if the inside is cleansed first. The inside cleansing GENERATES the outside cleanness. The becoming is conditional, not guaranteed. It requires the inside work.

5. **"Clean" as righteous and holy**: The Greek kaθaρos (clean) has semantic categories `morality_spirituality>righteousness_holiness` and `ritual>purity_rite`. The outside doesn't just become spotless — it becomes RIGHTEOUS, HOLY, PURE. The Pharisees' outside cleanness (v25) was a performance; the cleanness Jesus promises (v26) is real. The same word — kaθaρos — spans physical cleanness and moral holiness. Jesus uses it to say: real cleanness IS holiness.

6. **Singular "thou": from group to individual**: V25 addresses "you" (plural: scribes and Pharisees and hypocrites). V26 addresses "thou" (singular: one blind Pharisee). Jesus narrows from the group to the individual. The command is now personal — directed at one person. The shift makes the command more intimate and more challenging: this is about YOU, the one Pharisee who is blind. Jesus looks at one Pharisee and says: cleanse your own inside first.

7. **The same vessels: cup and platter as continuity**: Jesus uses the exact same words for "cup" and "platter" as in v25. The vessels don't change; the approach does. V25 describes the problem (outside clean, inside full from sin); v26 provides the remedy (cleanse the inside first). The cup is still a metaphor for one's LOT or FATE. The platter still dispenses bitterness. Jesus says: take the same vessels — but start from the other side.

8. **"Also" as the goal: both clean, inside first**: The Greek kaí ("also, too") encodes the goal: the outside may become clean ALSO — as well as the inside. Both clean. But the order matters: inside first, outside ALSO. The "also" means the cleanness SPREADS from inside to outside. V25's outside-only cleanness was performance; v26's inside-first cleanness generates outside cleanness ALSO — and that outside cleanness is now REAL (because it comes from the inside). The "also" is the promise: if you do the inside work, you get the outside cleanness too — but as a CONSEQUENCE, not as a performance.

Notes for Further Study

1. **The v25-v26 pair as problem-solution**: V25 and v26 form a direct pair — problem (outside-only cleansing concealing inside corruption) and solution (cleanse the inside first, that the outside may become clean also). Worth analyzing the pair as a unit and exploring how the grammatical shift (indicative → imperative, plural → singular) encodes the move from description to command.

2. **The connection to Matthew 8:2 (leprosy)**: The LSJ shows kaθarıze used in Ev.Matt. 8.2 for cleansing from leprosy. Jesus uses the same purification verb in v26. The connection suggests the inside of the cup is not just dirty but DISEASED — and the cure must start from within. Worth a full cross-reference analysis between v26 and 8:2.

3. **The middle voice gınomai (to cause to be)**: The use of middle voice in the purpose clause deserves further study. The middle voice is reflexive — the subject both acts and is affected. How does this interact with the purpose clause? Does the middle voice

always imply generation, or can it imply other causal relations? Worth examining other uses of gnomai in purpose clauses in the NT.

4. **The "blind" thread across vv24-26**: V24 calls them "blind guides." V26 addresses one as "thou blind Pharisee." The blindness persists — but Jesus' response shifts from description (v24: blind guides who strain at gnats) to command (v26: cleanse what you cannot see). Jesus is commanding the Pharisee to do the very thing his blindness prevents: to see and cleanse the inside. Worth exploring whether Jesus elsewhere commands people to act against their own limitations.

5. **Manuscript variants**: As with v25, worth verifying that v26 is consistent across Greek and ESV/KJV editions, especially given the known verse numbering discrepancies in the Matthew 23 pericope.

Analysis completed by: Peaches (4K Bible Translation Harness)
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